THE NEXT 100

ENTERTAINERS

CHARM OFFENSIVE

SANYA MALHOTRA, 29

Actor

There's an inherent, infectious charm to Sanya Malhotra which makes it near impossible to ignore her on screen. While *Dangal*, her debut, gave audiences a peek into her abilities, her talent was fully tapped in *Lunchbox* director Ritesh Batra's *Photograph*, a poignant drama in which Malhotra was fabulous as a shy, hesitant Gujarati girl who befriends a man older than her (Nawazuddin Siddiqui) and finds herself in the process.

She has only been in the industry for six years, but Sanya has hardly put a foot wrong. Her filmography thus far (including a supporting part in *Badhaai Ho*) shows a secure, assured actor eager to both entertain and experiment, and one that so far has cleverly steered clear of formulaic spectacles. She may not be seen as an audience-puller on the big screen yet but on the streaming platforms she has built and expanded her fan base with three direct-to-digital releases—*Ludo*, *Pagglait* and *Meenakshi Sundareshwar* (all on Netflix). From a widow struggling to grieve to a bride negotiating a long-distance relationship, the films showcase her range as an actress.

"Sanya is very meticulous. You can tell when actors have read the script 300 times. She's always trying to make it better"

RITESH BATRA
Filmmaker

The adulation that has come from fans has seen her quietly emerge as a contender, one with a winning personality and the acting chops to boot. With four films in the pipeline, including one said to feature Shah Rukh Khan, Sanya's star is on the rise.

–Suhani Singh



THOMAS NIEDERMUELLER/WIREIMAGE

HAPPY FEET Sanya, who's from Delhi, first came to Mumbai to audition for reality show *Dance India Dance*. She didn't get far but then stayed on in the city to pursue acting.